soon Lashkar would launch a third round.[106] Ten months later, the group executed its audacious fidayeen attack on the Red Fort in Delhi. A month after the attack Hafiz Saeed boasted, 'The action indicates that we have extended the jihad to India.'[107] Yet, while this was the first operation in India for which Lashkar took credit, in reality it had been involved in terrorist attacks there for almost a decade. According to one Indian security analyst, the Indian security services were arresting Pakistanis as early as 1992 who were tied to Lashkar, but at the time they did not know what Lashkar was since it was not big enough at the time to register clearly on their radar.[108] Thus, even before the state's decision to throw its support behind Lashkar and facilitate its expansion, the group was operating in India with the intention of building a network to execute or support terrorist attacks.

Initial recruitment and network-building took several forms. As in other countries with Muslim populations, Salafism was beginning to experience an upsurge in popularity in India during this time. Lashkar leveraged this surge in Salafi identity to inveigle recruits from Ahl-e-Hadith seminaries and other Salafi power centers, often relying on personal relationships forged via these seminaries and the Students' Islamic Movement of India [SIMI].[109] Very little open propagation was necessary, since SIMI and the various Ahl-e-Hadith seminaries in India provided a pool in which to fish for recruits. Above-ground Ahl-e-Hadith adherents, not necessarily or openly associated with Lashkar, helped to lay the groundwork and expand this recruiting pool through legitimate dawa operations intended to convert Indians to the Ahl-e-Hadith school of thought.[110]

More central to Lashkar's success was communal resentment in India, where the Muslim minority has suffered relative economic deprivation and some of whose members harbor a sense of political exclusion. In the words of the aforementioned analyst, the establishment has 'hammered Muslims quite badly' leading to significant disaffection.[111] Communal tension erupted into violence at times, such as in 1985 when pogroms targeting Muslims took place in the textile town of Bhiwandi. In response to this outbreak of violence, activists from the Jamaat Ghuraba Ahl-e-Hadith in India established a Muslim self-defense militia. Soon thereafter an obscure West Bengal-based cleric named Abu Masood announced the creation of Tanzim Islahul Muslimeen [Organization for the Improvement of Muslims